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INTERVIEWER - MW

OK, we're live. So to start us off. First question, what does occupational stress mean to you?

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FR05

Occupational stress to me obviously is a stress, all related with our job, which includes I think the very obvious things that everyone thinks about is seeing injuries, significant accidents, death, severe illness. I think that's very common in people. Think about that as very common occupational stress. But for me personally, I think one thing that's not very focused on and and effects me personally more than the job

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FR05

Actual on the job stress does, is your coworkers and interpersonal relationships within the the department, because especially with with the fire department, I think that there's just a lot of like grade-A personalities where everyone's just kind of like a little bit, I don't know, potheads the right way to say it, but everyone's kind of got their own idea of like what's right and what's wrong. And they just sometimes just people rub each other the wrong way. I think that that stresses me personally out more than anything else. So.

0:1:9.830 --> 0:1:13.70

INTERVIEWER - MW

That's interesting, man. Tell us. Tell us more about that.

0:1:13.160 --> 0:1:14.430

INTERVIEWER - MW

(inaudible)

0:1:17.30 --> 0:1:47.630

FR05

Uh, yeah, sure. So, like in particular, there's a lot, especially as a newer member of the department, despite I'm only obviously hittin [CLOSE TO A DECADE] working as a firefighter. But in the grand scheme of things, that's still very young in my career, but especially in my first few years and even up until, like I would say, even five years into my career it, it was incredibly stressful to be at a point where I understand the job enough to start be able to critically think and make decisions. But a lot of the older members of the department

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FR05

Have this mindset of trying to maybe not necessarily a mindset, but they have a personality where they they sometimes like to step on toes or like, overstep their boundaries on runs and just like

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FR05

For instance, if I'm like in charge I'm the medic and someone is

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FR05

Has a different idea of like what's happening on the run and they start questioning decisions I'm making that that's incredibly stressful when it's just like I'm I'm trying to make these decisions. I have this thought process I have and I want you to tell me if I'm gonna do something that's going to, like, kill a patient. But if it's like anything else benign or a personal decision, sometimes just people don't tend to just, like, let go of control. I think that's hard for a lot of people.

0:2:36.30 --> 0:2:41.780

INTERVIEWER - MW

Yeah, I can see that, especially in a profession like this, letting go of control, it could be

0:2:42.810 --> 0:2:47.300

INTERVIEWER - MW

A challenging. You guys get any type of training around that or or what does that even look like?

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FR05

Yeah. So we get plenty of command training. So to varying levels, obviously depending on where the incidence at and what trucks are out and available and what trucks aren't available. Sometimes you are the person that's in charge and I think everyone has good training. We get that training to know how to be in charge and make critical decisions. But I don't think that we have a good

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FR05

I don't know how to put it, but like a good I don't know if training or mindset would be a better term, but to be able to like I said like let go of control to someone to let them be able to do their job and make make critical decisions even if they are like a more junior member of the department.

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FR05

Cause that. That's incredibly stressful to to be a junior member of the department, be asked to do these jobs and then have older members of the department kind of kind of bulldoze you over on runs, taking over, making decisions for you when and then you get to this point where you're now a senior member of the department, but you haven't had the opportunity to be able to be in, in charge person, truly making decisions and having people just to be able to, like, accept your, your, your style of thinking and your your command.

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INTERVIEWER - MW

So good man, what?

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INTERVIEWER - MW

What do you feel would be helpful to you from the for stress reduction while on the job?

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FR05

Ohh well while on the job. For me personally I I love any sort of physical activity. I'm very much a

physical person. I personally do CrossFit, MMA, jujitsu as like my personal life outside of work stress relief. But while while on duty obviously just being able to

0:4:33.990 --> 0:5:6.300

FR05

Be able to be able to use the gym facilities. We just started doing this like yoga and mindfulness coordination with this lady that does a bunch of different fire departments here in [OUR AREA], so that that's a good step up in the right direction. So. But yeah, a lot of the on on the job stress reduction and I would say for me personally is physical activity, staying active and heck even like even just like regular training, even though that a lot of people see that as like work and busy work to

0:5:6.370 --> 0:5:14.260

FR05

Need to train for me personally, it just keeps my hands moving. Keeps my body like going doing something rather than just kind of sitting around and doing no stuff.

0:5:17.330 --> 0:5:17.730

INTERVIEWER - MW

Good.

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INTERVIEWER - MW

Describe a scenario where you felt overwhelmed during the job.

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FR05

Describe a what? A day that I felt overwhelmed on the job?

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INTERVIEWER - MW

Well, a scenario. Yeah. Like what's, what's the context look like when you're like, man, this is kind of you touched on it with some scenarios with you and your colleagues and then.

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INTERVIEWER - MW

You know, speaking over your shoulder in terms of how you should do things, I'm just curious to hear more about those scenarios.

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FR05

Yeah. So I personally have had a lot of stress related to uh, not only having people kind of step on your toes on runs, but it for me in particular, when either something happens on a run or in the middle of training and

0:6:5.230 --> 0:6:15.550

FR05

I feel like I haven't performed up to par that's incredibly stressful to me. For me personally, it's something that I personally have just have to just kind of work through.

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FR05

Just knowing that like it's something like ohh man, I should have known that I should have done this better. I should have known to like set this up to certain way. So like there's been plenty of times I've had a training scenario and that exact thing happens where

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FR05

I just didn't do something correctly and maybe it's not entirely the end of the world, but something that just didn't go as planned. And then I feel like it kind of snowballs into, like, OK, because I've done this incorrectly now on top of like the stress of, like, feeling like I've failed a task, I feel like

0:6:51.920 --> 0:7:8.530

FR05

Other members of department see that and see me failing and seeing that as like a another excuse to step on my toes even more because it's like, OK, clearly this guy doesn't know, doesn't know his job, and that could be just a lot of catastrophizing on my part. But it's it's definitely something that's at least in the back of my mind.

0:7:10.240 --> 0:7:11.930

INTERVIEWER - MW

And that I can definitely see.

0:7:12.690 --> 0:7:15.790

INTERVIEWER - MW

I'm saying it's kind of play off each other and they could be in your head.

0:7:16.610 --> 0:7:17.380

INTERVIEWER - MW

Quite a bit.

0:7:18.120 --> 0:7:25.530

INTERVIEWER - MW

What about from a like a physical side of thing? You have any chronic work related pain that you deal with at all?

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FR05

Ohh, it's hard for me to just to deter to determine what's work related. What's from me doing a bunch of different sports and activities I have. I personally have a [INJURY] in my [SHOULDER] and I'm not entirely sure. It just kind of like happened out of nowhere. I don't really recall a specific incident where I'm like, oh man, my shoulder really hurts, but just like I like about a year ago, I just started noticing like my shoulder again, like extra pain started going see the physical therapist and

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FR05

It's better now, but it's definitely not normal. So outside of that, I feel like I stay active enough and no proper body mechanics that I personally don't have any severe work related injuries or illnesses.

0:8:10.730 --> 0:8:11.120

INTERVIEWER - MW

Nice.

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INTERVIEWER - MW

So you mentioned you know you got the gym on the side. You get that up, you talked about some of the

0:8:17.790 --> 0:8:27.40

INTERVIEWER - MW

Yoga, mindful yoga incorporation. What- What other opportunities do you see for incorporating well-being resources into your daily workflow?

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FR05

So for me personally, and this is something I'm super passionate about, I go to counseling as well. And I'm also medicated [LISTS NAME OF MEDICINES]. I for all my friends that are going through any tough times because I've I've gone down, like, very dark road a couple of years ago. It's being in a very depressed place and just like going to counseling, even if it's not like you're not in a point where you're thinking about killing yourself, I think, honestly, counseling even just for just mild stress and day-to-day

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FR05

Umm, activity to be able to just like decompress and talk about stuff going on and kind of

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FR05

Like uh, really evaluate and reflect on your feelings. Is is so much so good for your your mental well-being.

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FR05

And yeah, and then like I said personally that that helped out a lot. I still had a lot of issues even with counseling after several months. So I started getting medicated personally with anxiety and antidepressants, which that has helped me significantly. So those are two things that I think there's there's some stigma. I don't think there's much stigma as people seem to think there is, but I definitely know there's some stigma with it, but something that I I definitely incorporate in my own life and recommend anyone else to incorporate.

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INTERVIEWER - MW

Are those?

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INTERVIEWER - MW

With the things you mentioned, are there things that you've kind of independently went and did or is that resources readily available through work or how does that look?

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FR05

Ohh yeah, so with work we have an employee assistance program so we it's through. I think it's called matrix matrix psychological services where you get

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FR05

Linked up with a therapist and you get 6 free counseling sessions a year and then anything after that it's out of your insurance. But yeah, we do have those resources available. You can call any of the officers and they'll they'll kind of like hook you up with some resources and phone numbers to call and yeah, but but that was definitely something I kind of realized for myself. That was it at a point where I I personally realized I needed help. So I sought that out myself. But.

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FR05

They are available at work and works also, they're trying to incorporate with [LOCAL UNIVERSITY] now to have like a some sort of like yearly mental about mental health like counseling thing I believe. So that hasn't started yet, but I hear it's in the works.

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INTERVIEWER - MW

What do you feel are some of the barriers playing a role and bringing even more well-being resources to your the workplace community than the firefighter community in general?

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FR05

I think a lot of it has to be a culture thing. I think with more younger members it's it's very easy, but with a lot of older members, I think there's like I mentioned, like stigmas attached with to like well-being, there's probably, there's definitely a level of like some people have reached this point in their career where they just don't care about their own well-being. They've kind of let themselves go, like physically, just like, not take care of their body, smoking a lot, or or what have you.

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FR05

So I think there's there's a lot of barriers that are culture and and

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FR05

Like care.

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FR05

Like uh care related, I'm not sure if that's the right term, but just some someone wanting to actually be part of that well-being, I think anyone.

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FR05

Especially more junior members are very open to that idea and open to like doing everything. But like I

said, I think a lot of it, a lot of older members and more culture is the biggest barriers that you have to introducing stuff like especially like mental, mental well-being and mental health awareness.

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INTERVIEWER - MW

So what are your thoughts regarding the incorporation of mindfulness practice into your daily work life?

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FR05

I personally find it very, very helpful, like I have a one of those, like mindfulness apps, like how it like leads you through like a a directed meditation thing that you know if I'm feeling stressed out I'll find a quiet place and just sit for a second.

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FR05

It's definitely helpful. Like I said, for me personally, it's very helpful. I recommend it for everyone else, but I think there's a lot of, like, yeah, just you. You can't force someone to do it. And especially like if you force someone to try and do that mindfulness stuff, I think it's not helpful at all. But I think if you, if you can make someone open to it, I personally think it's very helpful.

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INTERVIEWER - MW

What? What was it about the ad that was enticing to you versus some other form of mindfulness stress-reduction?

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FR05

Ohh, just being able to I had. I personally just have a very unquiet mind where if I try to do my own sort of like meditation, sitting in silence or whatever, I'm just

0:13:28.690 --> 0:13:47.380

FR05

Constantly thinking of like whatever is happening in my world or life, or that day at work. So having just something to kind of direct my mind to and and follow with my thoughts, it helps me not start wandering with my thoughts when I'm just by myself.

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INTERVIEWER - MW

You think your coworkers would be

0:13:54.760 --> 0:13:55.60

INTERVIEWER - MW

I guess

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INTERVIEWER - MW

Interested in using an app or how do you think it would be would be best received by them?

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FR05

Personally, I think most I would say I would not even hesitate to say like 90% of the department probably would think it's like a a joke. In all honesty, I think it, yeah, like I said, like it's a very much like a a cultural thing. There's like a handful of people I think would probably do it very legitimately and find a lot of use out of it. But I think most people probably would not take it seriously or would not personally see see the benefit for them.

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INTERVIEWER - MW

Hmm.

0:14:34.220 --> 0:14:36.850

INTERVIEWER - MW

Yeah, I mean, I hear you on that did

0:14:38.480 --> 0:14:39.150

INTERVIEWER - MW

What is it

0:14:39.890 --> 0:14:42.880

INTERVIEWER - MW

About the culture and you kind of touched on it though?

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INTERVIEWER - MW

What are some of the barriers that that culture brings?

0:14:49.150 --> 0:15:4.760

FR05

Ohh I I really couldn't put a big finger. I think a lot of it is probably your traditional kind of like masculine "I don't need help" kind of kind of culture. Kind of like, OK this.

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FR05

As much as people.

0:15:7.600 --> 0:15:14.40

FR05

Because like I I will say this, a lot of the officers and a lot of all the higher up staff definitely talk about like hey.

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FR05

Mental health is a good thing. Like you're not weak if you seek help like it's very much like talk told to us. Like no one saying like, hey, if you get help, you're you're you're an absolute p***y. But at the same time I.

0:15:27.770 --> 0:15:39.420

FR05

It's something that you can get told, but you can. I feel that most of the members of the department still feel that they don't need help or that it's it's like a sign of quitting or weakness.

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INTERVIEWER - MW

Yeah.

0:15:43.960 --> 0:15:45.600

INTERVIEWER - MW

So in an ideal world

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INTERVIEWER - MW

There was an app that existed. What type of what information will be important to include in that app?

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FR05

I like it. Like I said, probably directed meditation. I find breathing exercises very, very helpful.

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FR05

UM.

0:16:5.0 --> 0:16:7.510

FR05

If it could have like a one stop.

0:16:8.710 --> 0:16:29.240

FR05

Reference for different either psychological services to get hooked up with the counselor. Substance abuse counselors would be very helpful. I know that it's crazy, but we've had a few members of our department just have alcohol and other drug problems, and it's tough to kind of like

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FR05

See that happen and like try to find resources for them specifically, I think that would be good. Some substance abuse cause. Yeah, a lot of lot of

0:16:40.740 --> 0:16:48.660

FR05

Members of the department do get completely stressed out and do turn to kind of like terrible coping mechanisms like alcohol, like drugs.

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FR05

Definitely, probably some anger management. We'll probably be good as well. I think there's definitely a lot of members of department that get heated pretty quickly. That would be very beneficial.

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INTERVIEWER - MW

That's good. Who are- Who do you feel should be present in the videos? If there were videos that were presented like informational, who should be the one the authority speaking to that will be best received?

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FR05

I think it would be best received by by company level officers and even probably somewhere between

0:17:28.670 --> 0:17:59.440

FR05

Some more senior firefighters and like and like the first step, which is of officer, which are lieutenants because I feel like if you get any higher up depending on the person, some people might respect them. But a lot of people might think that they're just out of touch with what the line, what like what the common line firefighters are dealing with. Like if I had like [OUR CHIEF], he he spends 40 hours a week at the administration building in [LOCATION]. He does not come out to the stations. He does not go out on runs.

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FR05

And he doesn't see like what we go through or hang out with us, which is no knock on him. He he's got a lot on his plate. But if if he were to be on a video talking to us, I think there would be a lot of people that would interpret them, interpret that as a disingenuous.

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FR05

Even if it was very genuine, like a like, he doesn't understand like what's going on versus like having like.

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FR05

Your Lieutenant, and like your other, like peer coworkers talking about it, I feel like that that adds a lot of credence to what they're saying. And like, you're more likely to listen.

0:18:36.580 --> 0:18:37.60

INTERVIEWER - MW

Yeah.

0:18:38.490 --> 0:18:44.160

INTERVIEWER - MW

The man was there. Would you like? Is there anything I could go back? Discuss more? Do you feel like we we hit everything?

0:18:47.720 --> 0:18:59.280

FR05

Ohh yeah, no, I think. I think if we hit everything like what like I said for me personally there my, my personal experience was on the job stress is a lot more coworker in a personal relationship related.

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FR05

I'm definitely not the person to talk to you about, just like actual, like, seeing stuff on runs and how to decompress that. For me personally, I'm not bothered that much by it, but hopefully maybe someone else will talk to you can speak more to that, but if you have any more questions for me, I I feel like I've hit everything I've I would like to say.

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INTERVIEWER - MW

Yeah man, this was good. Crushed it. We appreciate it.

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FR05

All right, cool.